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Why do developers treasure XML? And why should you?

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If you've ever had someone do a job for you—be it setting up a Web site, making a Flash presentation, or bigger—even building a whole application for you—you know the dreadful feeling that overcomes you when you have to change the content. Getting in touch with the person, checking if he's free to do the job, the waiting, the watching, the possible paying, it's just too much! What if you could just use Notepad—yes, *Notepad*—to edit your content, and just sit back while it appears on your site automatically? The solution is close at hand. In fact, it's everywhere.

What Is It?

XML (eXtended Markup Language) is a document format that's been doing the rounds for many years now. Its purpose is to bring to the Web, and other areas, a way to represent structured data in a way that it can be used easily and quickly, without having to invest in a full-fledged database application. Why are we telling you about it? Because while it is mostly developers who keep fawning over it, there's a lot *you* can do with XML too. Its beauty lies in its simplicity—while it's really easy to learn, it's still ridiculously powerful. You can use it to organise your personal data, create and edit the content for your site or presentations, and even make your own RSS feeds.



Imaging Vikram Kathare

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